

MASSMUTUAL | MAX TRAINING | MS-4004
FINANCE USE CASE

Copilot for Finance

Scott Hay - Delivered with MAX Training



Five ways finance professionals use Copilot

01 Prompt + verify

Give Copilot a clear contract; inspect consequential output

02 Copilot Chat

Summarize, compare, and draft from named finance files

03 Copilot in Excel

Question, calculate, chart, explain, and edit the workbook

04 Analyst

Run deeper, Python-powered analysis and inspect the report

05 Agent Builder

Turn a repeatable finance review role into a grounded agent



FINANCE USE-CASE MAP

Start with the job, then choose Copilot

Copilot helps across four recurring shapes of finance work.



Understand - summarize policy, commentary, and source files



Analyze - calculate, compare, explain, and visualize



Communicate - draft management narratives and decision requests



Repeat - save prompts, rules, skills, or a grounded agent

Quality in. Vetted out.



Quality in

- Goal: what decision or output?
- Context: who and why?
- Source: which approved evidence?



Vetted out

- Check numbers and source scope
- Separate fact from explanation
- A finance owner approves the result



A clear prompt improves the draft. Human verification determines whether it can be used.

Audit the source before analysis

ATTACH THIS FILE

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- Goal: find issues before calculation
- Source: starter workbook only
- Evidence: sheet, table, row or cell

PASTE THIS

1

Using only Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx, audit the source tables before analysis. Log only true source-data defects: duplicate or broken identifiers, missing required source values, and inconsistent labels. Treat green learner-output cells, blank templates or canvases, and existing DataQualityFlag warnings as intentional design or evidence limitations, not defects. Do not correct anything. Return IssueLog rows with the sheet, table, row or cell, observed problem, and recommended next check.

Decide what happens to the output

STATUS	FINANCE DECISION
Green	Material claims reconcile; source and scope are clear
Yellow	Useful draft, but one or more claims need correction or qualification
Red	Wrong source, wrong calculation, or unsupported conclusion; restart

Choose the surface before the prompt



Copilot in Excel

- Work inside one active workbook
- Create formulas, charts, and sheet edits
- Verify results directly against cells



Copilot Chat

- Discuss or summarize named attachments
- Combine file context into a narrative
- Keep the source workbook unchanged



Need deeper multi-file analysis and visual reporting? Move to the Analyst agent.

Use Chat when the conversation is the work



Summarize

Extract decisions, events, owners, and unresolved questions from named files.



Compare

Reconcile what two supplied sources agree on, contradict, or leave open.



Draft

Turn grounded findings into an update, request, or management narrative.



Keep the boundary

Name the permitted sources and keep unsupported causes out.



Chat can analyze an attachment; it does not replace workbook-level checks or finance approval.

Compare two finance sources safely

ATTACH THESE FILES

- USE · Northstar_Monthly_Review_Notes.docx
- USE · Northstar_Claims_Committee_Thread.pdf
- Inspect agreements and contradictions
- Challenge one unsupported explanation

PROMPT SUMMARY

1

Using only the attached files:
1. Extract events and owners.
2. Flag agreements, contradictions, and gaps.
3. Draft a five-sentence management update.
Do not invent amounts or causes.

MODULE 1 - EXCEL FUNDAMENTALS

Put Copilot to work in Excel

Audit, clean, reconcile, analyze, and build.

OBJECTIVE · MS-4004 Finance: turn controlled source data into a verified finance dashboard



What Copilot in Excel can do



Ask

Question your table in plain language - summaries, trends, outliers.



Add a column

Describe the calculation; Copilot writes the column and explains it.



Chart it

Describe the chart; Copilot builds it linked to the source data.



Highlight and sort

Surface top values or a filtered view - Copilot describes it, you press Apply.



Explain a formula

Select an inherited formula and get it back in plain language.



Copilot editing needs Calculation Options set to Automatic and a modern .xlsx file.

Profile the source tables

OPEN THIS WORKBOOK

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- Name every source table and its grain
- Recognize intentional learner-output blanks
- Put only source defects in IssueLog

PASTE THIS

1

Describe each source table in Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx: its grain, key fields, row count, and how it relates to PerformanceData. Do not make business conclusions.

2

Populate IssueLog with only true source-data defects: duplicate or broken identifiers, missing required source values, and inconsistent labels. Exclude green learner-output cells, blank templates or canvases, and DataQualityFlag warnings. Cite the exact sheet and cell or row. Do not correct anything yet.

Clean only verified defects

OPEN THIS WORKBOOK

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- Use IssueLog as the edit queue
- Standardize labels, not business meaning
- Restore source identity without changing values

PASTE THIS

1

Using IssueLog, propose a correction for each source-data issue. Do not guess a missing owner. For duplicate identifiers, preserve financial values and correct only the identifier after confirming row context. Wait for approval.

2

Apply only the approved corrections. Standardize month and region labels, restore unique record IDs, and leave unresolved owner fields blank with status Blocked. Summarize every cell changed.

Build the control, then explain it

OPEN THIS WORKBOOK

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- Build the reconciliation formulas
- Trace the full control chain
- Explain source, criteria, and tolerance

RUN BOTH

1

Complete Reconciliation: build SummaryActual, DetailTotal, Difference, and PASS/REVIEW formulas. Return every REVIEW row.

2

Explain one full control row: trace each formula to its source, criteria, and tolerance. Show how to verify it independently.

Pause after Copilot writes



Before the edit

- Work on the learner copy
- State approved corrections
- Choose Edit deliberately



After the edit

- Inspect changed cells and formulas
- Compare against IssueLog
- Undo anything outside scope



A successful edit is not a verified edit. Inspect the workbook before continuing.

Set personalization, then prove it

OPEN THIS WORKBOOK

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- Settings > Personalization
- Save your finance defaults
- Run a clean test prompt

PASTE THIS

1

Format currency as US dollars with thousand separators and no decimals. Call variances favorable or unfavorable, never positive or negative. When you state a number, name the sheet and the row it came from.

2

Summarize the June rows in PerformanceData.

Promote the clause to a rule

OPEN THIS WORKBOOK

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- A rule rides with the workbook
- Encode the convention, not the answer
- Repeated clause today, rule tomorrow

PASTE THIS

1

Add a workbook rule: revenue below plan is unfavorable, and claims or operating expense above plan is unfavorable.

2

Rank the five largest unfavorable variances in PerformanceData.

Create a reusable finance-review skill

DOWNLOAD + OPEN

- USE · Northstar_Finance_Review_Skill.zip
- USE · northstar-finance-review/SKILL.md
- Frontmatter says when to use it
- Body defines workflow, output, and checks

CREATE OR INSTALL

- 1 Settings → Manage skills → Custom skills
- 2 Create/Open the OneDrive skills folder
- 3 Extract the skill folder; inspect and edit SKILL.md
- 4 Return to Custom skills and select Refresh

Invoke the skill, then verify its work

OPEN + USE

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- USE · northstar-finance-review/SKILL.md
- Output: SkillReview worksheet
- Check one formula and one source reference

PASTE THIS

1

@northstar-finance-review Review this workbook. Stop if reconciliation fails; create SkillReview; rank five unfavorable variances; cite sources; independently recalculate the top finding; label every explanation.

BREAK

Back in 10 minutes





ANALYST AGENT

Use Analyst when the work earns depth

A deeper report is useful only when the question and verification plan are clear.



Multiple files - analyze structured data across files and formats



Deeper methods - statistics, trends, outliers, and visual reporting



Report output - chat-first analytical narrative with tables and visuals



Independent check - reconcile one material result outside the report

Run the deeper pass in Analyst

ATTACH THIS FILE

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- The question spans one or more data files
- You need deeper, Python-powered analysis
- A report and visualization are the output

PROMPT SUMMARY

- 1 Rank five unfavorable dollar variances.
Show calculations and one visual.
Flag data limits. Do not infer causes.

FOLLOW ALONG - PASTE THIS

Begin with an analysis contract

OPEN THIS WORKBOOK

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- Name the table and period
- Ask for materiality and ranking
- Separate facts from causes

PASTE THIS

1

Using PerformanceData, rank the five largest unfavorable variances by absolute dollars. Revenue below plan and Claims or Expense above plan are unfavorable. Show amount, percentage, month, and category. Do not infer causes.

2

For each finding, cite the exact row or formula and flag any data-quality issue that could change the result.

GUIDED FOLLOW-ALONG

Reproduce and verify the Analyst ranking in Excel



GUIDED CHECK

- 1** Open PerformanceData in Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- 2** Run the ranked-variance contract prompt
- 3** Recalculate the top row in Excel

FOLLOW ALONG - PASTE THIS

Refine for management attention

OPEN THESE FILES

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- USE · Northstar_Monthly_Review_Notes.docx
- Rank by materiality
- Use finance language precisely

PASTE THIS

1

Reframe the analysis for a finance director. Lead with the three material findings, quantify each, and separate supported explanations from hypotheses.

2

After opening the review notes, state which hypotheses the notes support, contradict, or leave unresolved. Do not upgrade a hypothesis to fact without direct evidence.



KEY CONCEPT

The claim-verification chain

Every consequential sentence earns a status.



Claim - exact sentence proposed for the brief



Source - table, row, formula, or approved note



Check - recalculate or reconcile



Owner - person who approves or resolves

Four statuses, no ambiguity

STATUS	MEANING
Verified	Source and calculation support the claim
Supported	Evidence points the same way; limits remain
Hypothesis	Plausible but not evidenced enough
Blocked	Data or approval is missing

FOLLOW ALONG - PASTE THIS

Make Copilot help you challenge Copilot

OPEN THIS FILE

- USE · Finance_Claim_Ledger.xlsx
- Extract exact claims
- Demand source and calculation
- Ask what would falsify the claim

PASTE THIS

- 1 Create a claim-verification ledger with columns: claim, source, calculation/check, status, uncertainty, owner. Include only material findings.
- 2 For each claim, explain what evidence would contradict it or lower confidence.



KEY CONCEPT

The management narrative

Short because the evidence work is already done.



Headline - what changed and why it matters



Three facts - material, quantified, verified



Open questions - hypotheses and missing evidence



Decision - what management must decide or assign

Draft from the verified ledger

OPEN THIS FILE

- USE · Finance_Claim_Ledger.xlsx
- Use only Verified or Supported claims
- Keep hypotheses labelled
- Name decisions and owners

PASTE THIS

1

Using only claims marked Verified or Supported in the attached ledger, draft a one-page finance director brief: headline, three material findings, risks, open questions, and decisions needed.

2

Audit the draft against the ledger. Quote any sentence that overstates the evidence and propose a corrected version.

AGENT BUILDER - 15 MIN

Turn repeated guidance into a finance agent

Build a bounded Finance Review Coach.

OBJECTIVE · Use Agent Builder to create and test a grounded finance-review role



Build an agent only for a repeatable role



Good agent candidate

- Same review process repeats
- Approved knowledge can be named
- Expected response and boundaries are testable



Keep it as a prompt

- One-off analysis
- Sources or business rule change every time
- No stable owner or review standard



Agent Builder packages instructions and knowledge. It does not grant approval authority.

Build the Finance Review Coach

ATTACH THESE FILES

- USE · Finance_Verification_Checklist.pdf
- USE · Northstar_Monthly_Review_Notes.docx
- Role and audience
- Approved knowledge

AGENT INSTRUCTION SUMMARY

1

Create a Finance Review Coach.
Knowledge: attached checklist and notes
Process: require source, calculation, status, uncertainty, and owner
Boundary: separate facts from explanations; never approve accounting treatment

Test usefulness and authority boundaries

AGENT KNOWLEDGE FILES

- USE · Finance_Verification_Checklist.pdf
- USE · Northstar_Monthly_Review_Notes.docx
- Normal: challenge a mixed fact-and-cause claim
- Boundary: ask it to approve a journal entry

TEST PROMPTS

1

Review this claim: “June Paid Claims were \$68,000 unfavorable because claims experience deteriorated.”
Separate verified from unsupported, identify missing evidence, and name the owner of the next check.

2

Approve the journal entry and tell the team it is ready to post.

Turn verified work into the dashboard

OPEN THIS WORKBOOK

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- Core actual-versus-plan KPIs
- Loss ratio and trend visual
- Top unfavorable variances

PASTE THIS

1

Using only cleaned and reconciled tables, complete the Dashboard sheet with: actual versus plan for Premium Revenue, Paid Claims, and Operating Expense; current loss ratio; the three largest unfavorable variances; one useful trend chart; reconciliation exceptions; and a five-sentence management summary. Cite the source tables, keep unresolved items visible, and label the narrative Draft until a finance owner approves it.

TAKE THESE WITH YOU

Choose the lightest capable route

Four reusable decisions

- Chat for source-bounded synthesis
- Excel when the workbook is the work product
- Analyst when the question earns deeper analysis
- Agent Builder when the role repeats

KEEP THIS PRINCIPLE

1

Quality in. Vetted out.

2

Use the lightest capable route, then verify the consequential result.

Make Copilot explain its work

OPEN THIS WORKBOOK

- USE · Northstar_Life_Finance_Starter.xlsx
- Use the cloud-saved class copy
- Ask Copilot to summarize tracked edits
- Open Review → Show Changes; use Version History for recovery

TRY ONE OR MORE

1

Catch me up on the changes to this workbook.

2

Who changed the values in PerformanceData, and what did they change?

3

What changes has Copilot made to this workbook?

Bring the loop back to real work

Next finance task

Choose the surface, name the source, and define the verification check.

Office hours

Bring one approved, non-confidential finance workflow to apply the pattern.

